

A CONTRARIAN READING OF 1,000 STARTUPS

Quiet Money

Startup culture rewards noise. The revenue doesn't.

Across 1,000 startups on TrustMRR, the signals founders are told to chase — follower counts, the hottest category, a public brand, a headline growth rate — show almost no relationship with what a business actually earns. The companies quietly making real money often look nothing like what “building in public” tells you to build.

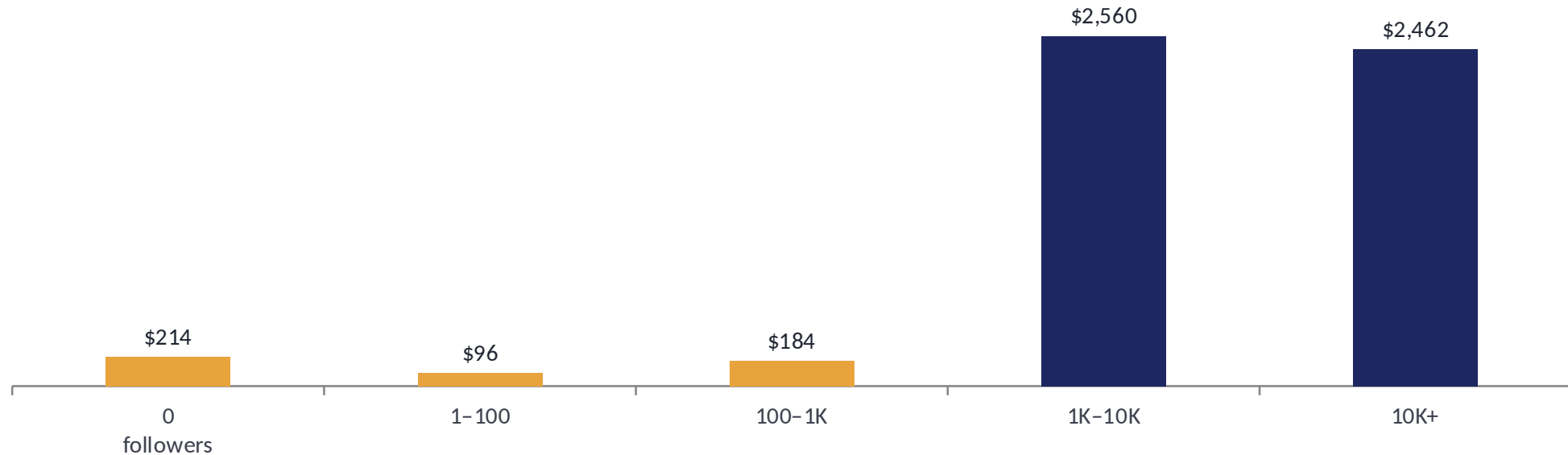
Source: TrustMRR public listings dataset, 1,000 startups, frozen 30 Jul 2026

CLAIM 1 • AUDIENCE

A bigger following buys you almost nothing

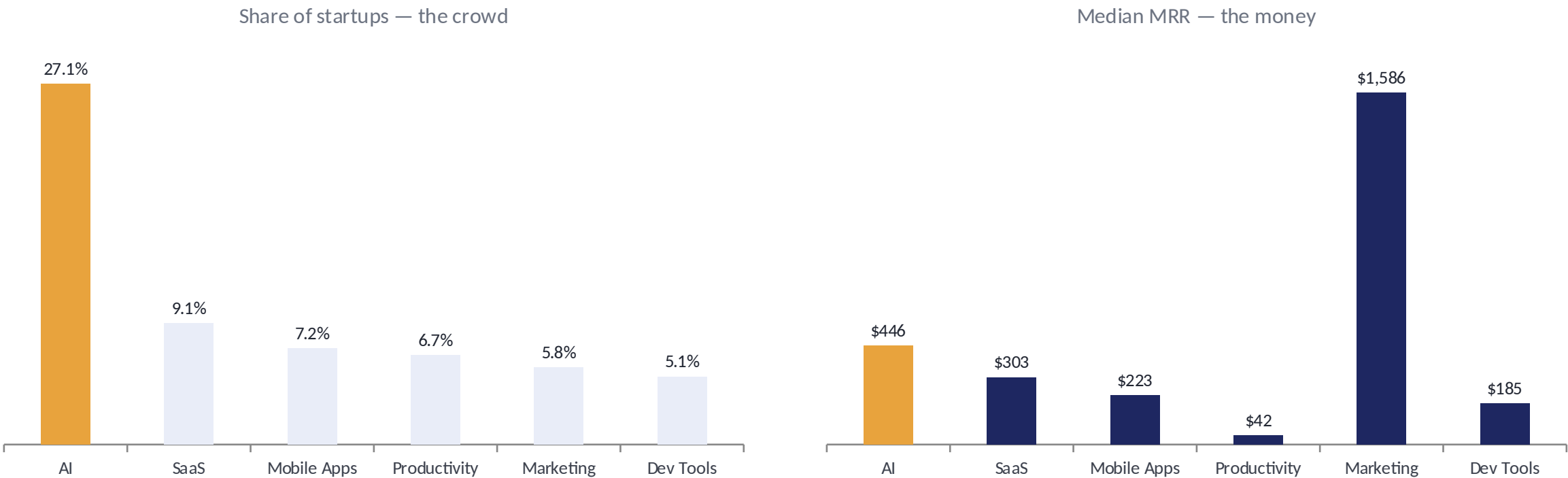
Across all 1,000 startups, X follower count and monthly revenue are essentially uncorrelated ($r = 0.02$). Founders are told an audience is the moat. The data says: it stops mattering almost immediately. Median revenue barely moves from 0 followers to 1,000 followers — and going from 1K to 10K+ followers doesn't buy you more, it buys you slightly less.

Median MRR by follower count — the line goes flat, then bends down



Everyone piled into the hottest label. It didn't pay off.

27% of every labeled startup calls itself “AI” — more than the next five categories combined. It's the loudest word in the dataset. Yet the typical AI startup earns \$446/month, below Marketing, Education, and Analytics, categories nobody's excited to tweet about. Piling into the hype label bought founders competition, not revenue.



The fastest “growing” startups are usually the smallest

One listing in this dataset reports 12,983% month-over-month MRR growth. It sounds like a rocket ship. It's a company that went from a few hundred dollars to \$135K — a base-effect illusion, not momentum. Take the top 5% of startups by reported growth rate: their median MRR is \$145. The rest of the dataset's median is \$514 — over 3x higher. The steepest growth-rate headlines are coming from the smallest, least meaningful bases.

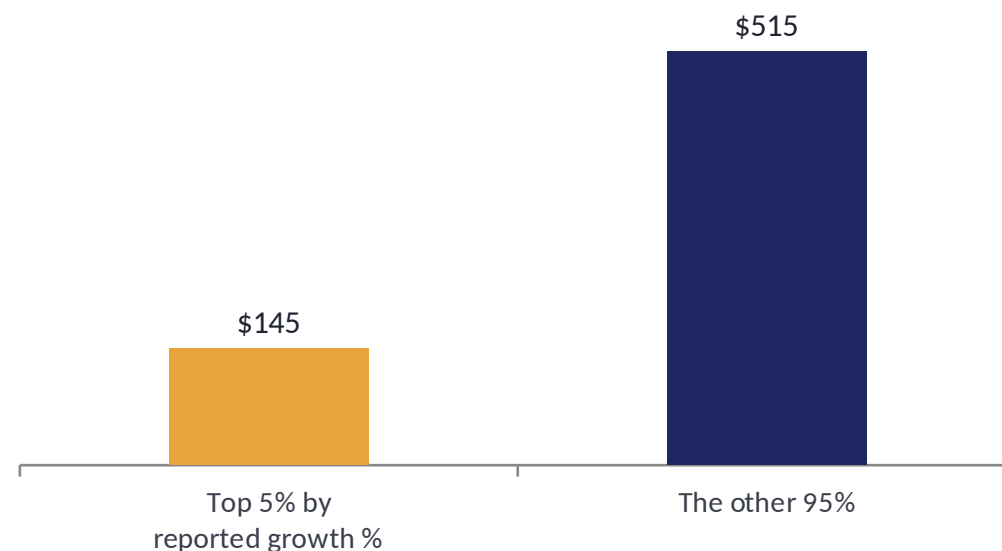
12,983%

the single wildest reported growth rate — on a near-zero base

\$145 vs \$514

median MRR: top 5% “growth” startups vs. everyone else

Growth-rate leaders vs. the field

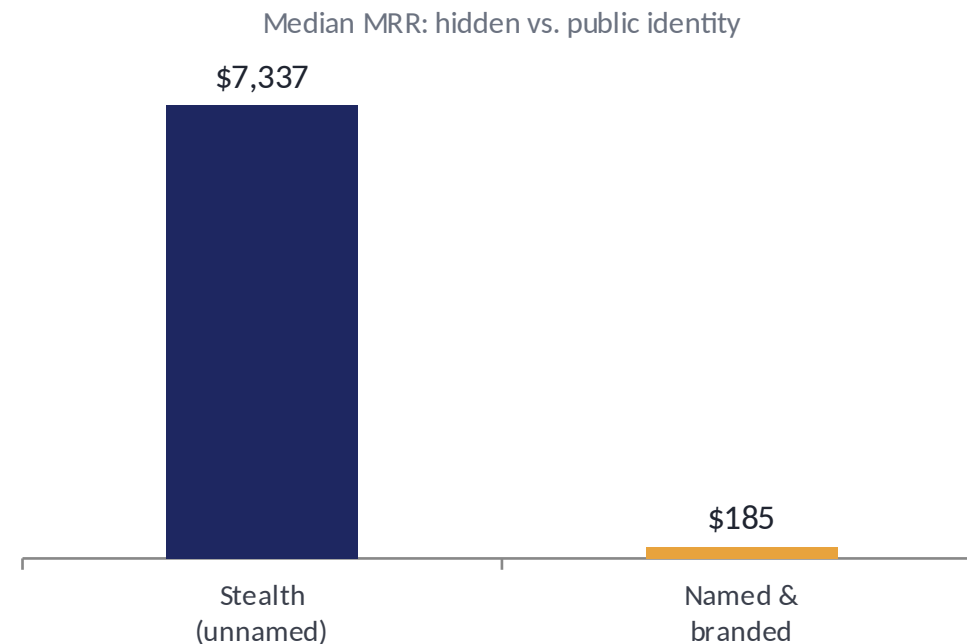


The best-performing businesses aren't even named

129 listings hide behind “Stealth Company” — no name, no website, no public brand. Their median MRR is \$7,337. Named, branded, publicly-visible startups post a median of \$185. That's a 40x gap, in favor of the ones hiding. And it isn't just sellers scrubbing identity before a quick flip — stealth listings are actually slightly less likely to be for sale (24%) than named ones (27%). These founders are choosing invisibility while the revenue keeps compounding.

Not a sale artifact

24% of stealth listings are for sale vs. 27% of named ones — almost identical. These aren't businesses hiding to look good for a buyer. They're built to stay quiet.



CLAIM 5 • AUDIENCE TYPE

Nobody goes viral selling to businesses. That's the point.

B2C is the crowded, glamorous lane — 401 startups chase consumers, more than any other audience. But the typical B2B startup earns \$1,036/month, nearly 6x the \$181 a typical B2C startup makes, with 146 fewer competitors in the category. Businesses pay for tools that save them time or money. Consumers scroll past your landing page. Boring, unglamorous, B2B is where the revenue actually is.

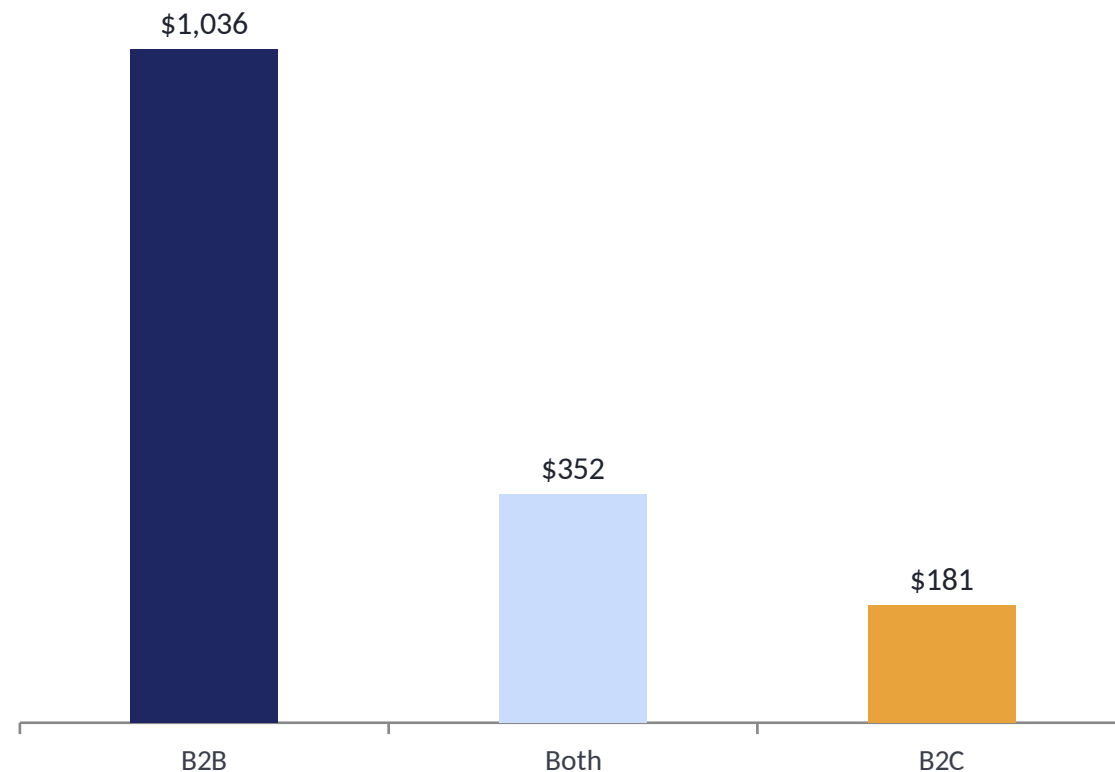
255

B2B startups — the smaller, quieter crowd

401

B2C startups — the crowded, loud lane

Median MRR by audience type



Buyers don't believe the hype either

262 of these startups are listed for sale. The median price is \$35,000, at a median multiple of just 2.3x monthly revenue. Venture investors pay 5–10x annual revenue for durable SaaS. Buyers here are paying a fraction of that — because they already know what this whole deck has been showing: a follower count, a hot category label, and a scary growth-rate screenshot don't make revenue durable. Buyers price the discount in. You should too.

262 / 1,000

startups on the market right now

\$35,000

the median asking price

2.3x MRR

vs. 5–10x ARR for VC-backed SaaS

THE VERDICT

The market doesn't reward noise. It rewards revenue.

1

Stop optimizing for followers.

Audience size stops predicting revenue almost immediately — build the product, not the feed.

2

Don't chase the hottest label.

AI has the most founders and a below-average payout. Crowded isn't the same as profitable.

3

Ignore your growth-rate screenshot.

The fastest “growing” startups have the smallest bases. Check absolute revenue, not the percentage.

4

You don't need a public brand to win.

The highest-earning listings in this dataset don't even have a name attached.

5

Sell to businesses, not crowds.

B2B earns 6x more per company than B2C, with far less competition for attention.